

QUEENSBORO BRIDGE

DOT Starts Work to Open Queensboro Roadway to Pedestrians

Work is finally beginning on the Queensborough Bridge's future pedestrian path.



By **Kevin Duggan**



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The suicide prevention fence has gone up on the Queensborough Bridge, seen here in Long Island City. Photo: Gersh Kuntzman

Work is finally underway to turn a car lane on the Queensboro Bridge into a pedestrian lane, seven years after the Department of Transportation first revealed the plan and two years behind schedule.

DOT erected “suicide-prevention fencing” along parts of the South Outer Roadway of the bridge in recent weeks — the first step toward giving the near

3,000 daily pedestrians and 7,000 cyclists separate space on the crossing, one of the busiest cycling stretches in the city.

Cyclists, pedestrians and other micromobility users routinely crash into each other on the tight path, and have for years — even before the number of people (and e-bikes) on the bridge skyrocketed during the pandemic.

“It’s insane that we had to wait for the fence at all, given the Triboro [Bridge] doesn’t have one, but if this is one of the final boxes for them to check, I’m glad to see them checking it,” said Laura Shepard, a Queens organizer with Transportation Alternatives.

“The city has been on notice for years about this problem and it is their responsibility to provide a safe facility for walking and biking.”

Of the four East River bridges, the Queensboro is second in bike traffic only to the Williamsburg Bridge, which has a wide, dedicated path. Nearly 10,000 cyclists and pedestrians use the Queensboro each day, far outnumbering the fewer than 8,200 daily drivers who take the South Outer Roadway, DOT officials told a Manhattan community board in April.

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DOT has promised to open the south outer roadway to people on foot by “late summer,” and a pol representing the Queens side hoped the agency would keep

its word.

“After years of delays, broken promises, and missed deadlines, construction to convert the Queensboro Bridge south outer roadway to a pedestrian-only walkway has finally begun,” said Council Member Julie Won. “I am hopeful that the Department of Transportation will keep its word and open the walkway to pedestrians by the end of the summer, making the bridge safer for all who use it.” (Summer ends on Sept. 21.)

Agency officials have repeatedly pushed back that deadline before in order to keep the south outer roadway open to drivers during a rehab of the bridge’s upper deck — sacrificing safety to prevent 5 percent more car congestion.

The delays prioritize the convenience of motorists over the safety of everyone else. People kept crashing into each other on the existing bike-ped shared path, including as recently as last week, according to a social media post.

“We’re still hearing about crashes and injuries that would have been prevented if we had more space,” said Shepard.

DOT agreed to look into opening both roadways back in 2017, and former Mayor Bill de Blasio in 2021 announced he would implemented the overhaul by the end of 2022.

Once the revamp is done, motorists will still have *four other lanes* on the bridge to drive to the World’s Borough. The Queens-bound south outer roadway has already been closed to cars overnight for a decade, because drivers kept speeding off the off-ramp and crashing, including in one incident that killed an off-duty cop, QNS reported at the time.

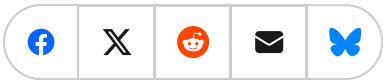
DOT officials cited the anti-suicide fencing as a prerequisite to any future pedestrian path, along with new infrastructure on both ends of the overpass.

The agency will build out a new concrete landing for pedestrians on the Long Island City side, and crosswalks and sidewalk extensions to connect to Second Avenue over in Manhattan.

Some of the new infrastructure will still be in construction after the path is open to walk on, officials said.

DOT declined to comment.

If you or someone you know is thinking about suicide, counselors are available 24/7 to listen and support you at [988](#). If you are unable to intervene, or in immediate danger because of a health condition or other situation, call 911.



Kevin Duggan

Kevin Duggan joined Streetsblog in October, 2022, after covering transportation for amNY. Duggan has been reporting on New York since 2018, starting at Vince DiMiceli’s Brooklyn Paper, where he covered southern Brooklyn neighborhoods and, later, Brownstone Brooklyn. He is on Bluesky at [@kevinduggan.bsky.social](#) and his email address is kevin@streetsblog.org.

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